



22 June 1941

GERMANY INVADES THE USSR

Turning his back on the 1939 Nazi-Soviet Non-Aggression Pact, Hitler ordered a mass assault on the Soviet Union over a front 2,900km (1,800 miles) long and involving almost 3 million men. Despite early successes, the invasion soon became a war of attrition; and by opening this second front and forcing the USSR to link up with the Allied powers, Hitler was soon to find his forces under huge pressure.

◀ Soviet propaganda poster

6 April 1941 Germany invades Yugoslavia, forcing a surrender within 10 days

9 October 1941 The Manhattan Project's atomic research begins in the US

1941

7 December 1941

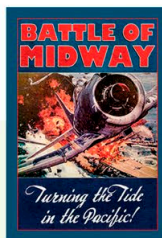
JAPAN BOMBS PEARL HARBOR

Japan's military leadership launched a surprise air attack on the US naval base at Pearl Harbor in Hawaii, the headquarters of the Pacific Fleet. A dozen warships were destroyed and over 2,400 servicemen killed. The raid brought the US into the war on the Allied side.

▷ US warships under attack at the Pearl Harbor naval base



1941-45 WAR IN THE PACIFIC



The Japanese began their Pacific expansion in 1941, capturing Singapore, Burma's capital Rangoon, and the Dutch East Indies.

April 1942 US troops defending the Philippines surrender to the Japanese on the Bataan Peninsula.

May-June 1942 US naval forces turn the tide of the Pacific conflict by defeating Japanese fleets at the battles of the Coral Sea and Midway.

7 August 1942 Landing on Guadalcanal in the Solomon Islands, US forces start an island-hopping offensive, driving north towards Japan.

21 June 1945 Okinawa, at the southernmost tip of the Japanese archipelago, is captured by US forces after a long struggle.